AUCKLAND, NEW ZEALAND

Auckland Art Gallery Toi o Tāmaki: Masterpieces

Portraits, coastal landscapes and historical scenes show what framing brings forward and leaves outside.



Tall grass can interrupt a coastal prospect rather than politely stepping aside for it. Domestic objects can make a portrait more specific without explaining every part of the sitter's life. In this selection, the position from which a subject is shown often matters as much as the subject itself. Rita Angus's firmly organised images sit beside landscapes whose distances emerge through lighter, less closed marks.

Historical scenes need a different question. Clayton's later paintings of a voyage and a colonial arrival in this selection are reconstructions, not eyewitness views of those events. Reading how these pictures arrange ships, people and shorelines is part of understanding the history of representation as well as the event named in the title.

Artline selected these works from documented museum holdings. The selection is independent of the museum, and individual works may be on loan or off display. Dates and attributions retain the qualifications in the linked records.

Explore this selection in Artline

See the selected works alongside books and events from their period, or compare when the artists lived. The books and events provide context, not evidence of direct influence. Works without confirmed dates remain in this guide.

Artworks in context Who lived when?

artlines.org/guides/auckland-art-gallery

The selection · 20

1. Portrait of Betty Curnow
   Rita Angus · 1942
2. Mangonui
   Rita Angus · 1955
3. Lupin
   Rita Angus · 1953
4. Fog, Hawke's Bay
   Rita Angus · 1969
5. AD 1968
   Rita Angus · 1968
6. Head of a Māori Boy
   Rita Angus · 1938
7. Pōhutukawa
   Clas Edvard Fristrom · c. 1905
8. Piha Heads
   Clas Edvard Fristrom · 1903–1915
9. Gum Trees, Great North Road, Grey Lynn
   Clas Edvard Fristrom · 1903
10. Piha Valley
    Clas Edvard Fristrom · 1903–1915
11. The Mill Valley, Karekare Bay
    Frank Wright · 1899
12. Morning after Rain
    Frank Wright · 1912
13. The Last Gleam
    Frank Wright · 1912
14. HMS Resolution and HMS Adventure off Cape Palliser
    Matthew Thomas Clayton · 1898
15. Landing of Lieutenant Governor Hobson at Waitangi
    Matthew Thomas Clayton · 1896
16. Queen Street, Auckland
    Jacques Carabain · 1889
17. Auckland from the Wharf
    Edward Augustus Gifford · 1887
18. A Settler's Kitchen, Opua Whanga
    Robert Atkinson · 1886
19. A Cavalry Battle
    Salvator Rosa · 1652
20. The Obsequies of an Egyptian Cat
    John Reinhard Weguelin · 1886

01 / 20

Portrait of Betty Curnow

Rita Angus

1942 · Auckland Art Gallery Toi o Tāmaki



Rita Angus. Portrait of Betty Curnow. Image: WikiArt. Copyright protected (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Copyright protected (WikiArt label)

Betty Curnow's direct gaze and settled hands hold the portrait together amid books, pictures and patterned cloth. Angus makes the surroundings participate in the likeness without allowing them to swallow the sitter. The face retains its clear position within a crowded field. The setting offers associations and material particulars, not a licence to turn every object into a fixed personality trait.

Object source · Open artwork

02 / 20

Mangonui

Rita Angus

1955 · Auckland Art Gallery Toi o Tāmaki



Rita Angus. Mangonui. WikiArt source label: Rita Angus Fair Use. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/rita-angus/mangonui-1955 · Rita Angus Fair Use (WikiArt source label)

The small boat makes the pale water measurable, while low hills and broad cloud marks establish the harbour with relatively few divisions. Angus leaves intervals around the coloured passages, allowing the paper to contribute to the light. Openness is constructed as carefully as density: unfilled areas can be active parts of a landscape rather than gaps awaiting completion.

Object source · Open artwork

03 / 20

Lupin

Rita Angus

1953 · Auckland Art Gallery Toi o Tāmaki



Rita Angus. Lupin. WikiArt source label: Rita Angus Fair Use. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/rita-angus/lupin-1953 · Rita Angus Fair Use (WikiArt source label)

The yellow flowers gather densely near the foreground, but separate marks preserve differences within the growth. Above them, the handling opens into shrubs and lightly indicated sky. Angus makes a change of spacing carry the transition from plants to air. The modest subject offers a close example of how much structure can be established without architectural lines.

Object source · Open artwork

04 / 20

Fog, Hawke's Bay

Rita Angus

1969 · Auckland Art Gallery Toi o Tāmaki



Rita Angus. Fog, Hawke's Bay. WikiArt source label: Rita Angus Fair Use. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/rita-angus/fog-hawkes-bay-1969 · Rita Angus Fair Use (WikiArt source label)

The road and telegraph poles insist on clear directions while the pale cloud masses resist them. Angus holds those conditions together rather than allowing fog to dissolve the whole view. Houses retain their sharply described forms, so the atmosphere is measured against something firm. The painting's uncertainty belongs to the weather, not to an inability to organise the scene.

Object source · Open artwork

05 / 20

AD 1968

Rita Angus

1968 · Auckland Art Gallery Toi o Tāmaki



Rita Angus. AD 1968. WikiArt source label: Rita Angus Fair Use. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/rita-angus/ad-1968-1968 · Rita Angus Fair Use (WikiArt source label)

Seahorses, rings, letters and a raised circular form are individually recognisable, yet their arrangement does not describe an ordinary place. Angus gives the improbable assembly a clear surface, withholding an equally clear explanation. The first useful task is to notice how the elements coexist. Naming them is possible; translating their entire relationship into one message is less secure.

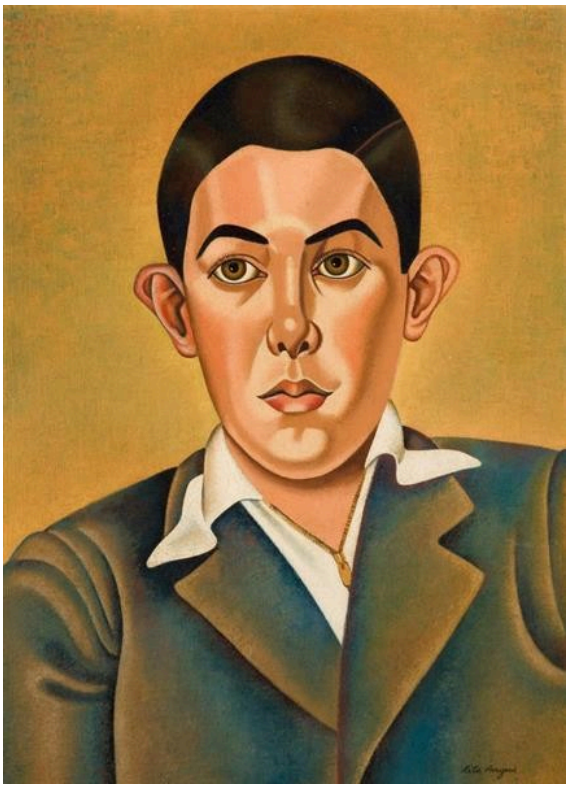
Object source · Open artwork

06 / 20

Head of a Māori Boy

Rita Angus

1938 · Auckland Art Gallery Toi o Tāmaki



Rita Angus. Head of a Maori Boy. Image: WikiArt. Copyright protected (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Copyright protected (WikiArt label)

The plain warm ground gives the outlined face little competition. Small differences around the eyes and mouth interrupt the frontal arrangement, while the open collar breaks the jacket's darker mass. Angus establishes individuality through those limited variations. The title's general identification should not encourage treating the sitter as a representative type in place of a particular depicted person.

Object source · Open artwork

07 / 20

Pōhutukawa

Clas Edvard Friström

c. 1905 · Auckland Art Gallery Toi o Tāmaki



Clas Edvard Friström. Pohutukawa. Image credit: Clas Edvard Friström; Source credit: https://ehive.com/collections/3236/objects/1351/pohutukawa. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The tree spreads low across the coast, making its silhouette the main structure of the picture. Small red flowers interrupt the dark crown without breaking its unity. Friström gives the broad blue sky a largely continuous role: it lets each bend of the tree remain legible. The species is approached through a particular pattern of growth.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1967/9/1

08 / 20

Piha Heads

Clas Edvard Fristrom

1903–1915 · Auckland Art Gallery Toi o Tāmaki



Clas Edvard Fristrom. Piha Heads. Image credit: Clas Edvard Fristrom; http://www.aucklandartgallery.com/explore-art-and-ideas/artwork/3004/piha-heads. https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Edward_Fristr%C3%B6m_-_Piha_Heads_-_1961-27-2_-_Auckland_Art_Gallery.jpg. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame resize and JPEG compression; applicable ShareAlike terms retained. · Public domain

The foreground grass does not yield an unobstructed prospect. It partly conceals the rocks and sea, making the viewer's position within near vegetation consequential. Fristrom lets a landscape be encountered through impediments. The coast is still identifiable, but it comes in fragments rather than as a neatly detached vista ready to be taken in at once.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1961/27/2

09 / 20

Gum Trees, Great North Road, Grey Lynn

Clas Edvard Friström

1903 · Auckland Art Gallery Toi o Tāmaki



Clas Edvard Friström. Gum Trees, Great North Road, Grey Lynn. Image credit: Clas Edvard Friström; http://www.aucklandartgallery.com/explore-art-and-ideas/artwork/2756/gum-trees-great-north-road-grey-lynn. https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Edward_Fristr%C3%B6m_-_Gum_Trees,_Great_North_Road,_Grey_Lynn_-_1956-6-4_-_Auckland_Art_Gallery.jpg. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame resize and JPEG compression; applicable ShareAlike terms retained. · Public domain

The tall trees give this stretch of road a scale different from that of the low buildings beyond. Light recovers portions of trunks and rough ground, linking the street to less ordered surfaces at its edge. The landscape is neither simply built nor untouched. Its particular character comes from the contact between road, settlement and established growth.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1956/6/4

10 / 20

Piha Valley

Clas Edvard Friström

1903–1915 · Auckland Art Gallery Toi o Tāmaki



Clas Edvard Friström. Piha Valley. Image credit: Clas Edvard Friström; http://www.aucklandartgallery.com/explore-art-and-ideas/artwork/3003/piha-valley. https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Edward_Fristr%C3%B6m_-_Piha_Valley_-_1961-27-1_-_Auckland_Art_Gallery.jpg. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame resize and JPEG compression; applicable ShareAlike terms retained. · Public domain

The cool blue of the tree separates it from warmer grass even where outlines remain loose. Friström uses colour temperature to distinguish neighbouring areas of growth. The hillside holds the view at a modest depth rather than opening an enormous prospect. Within that enclosure, a change in hue can do the organising work of a sharply drawn boundary.

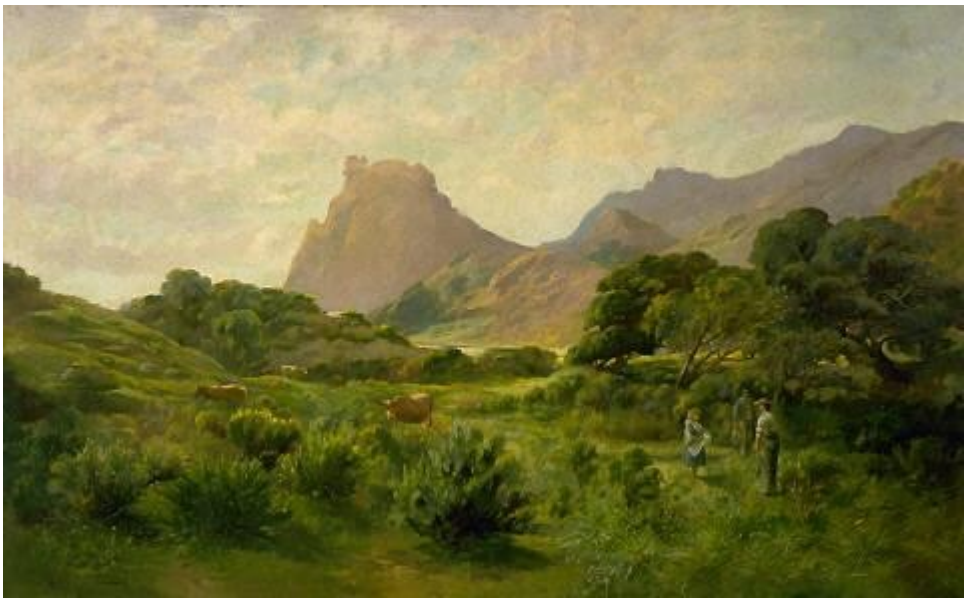
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1961/27/1

11 / 20

The Mill Valley, Karekare Bay

Frank Wright

1899 · Auckland Art Gallery Toi o Tāmaki



Frank Wright. The Mill Valley, Karekare Bay. Image credit: Frank Wright; Source credit: http://www.aucklandartgallery.com/explore-art-and-ideas/artwork/167/the-mill-valley-karekare-bay. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Dense vegetation could make the valley difficult to read, but overlapping ridges divide it into successive distances. Wright lets those ridges grow paler as they recede. The scene changes scale as the eye moves from near growth to mountain profiles. Complexity is retained locally while the larger structure remains intelligible.

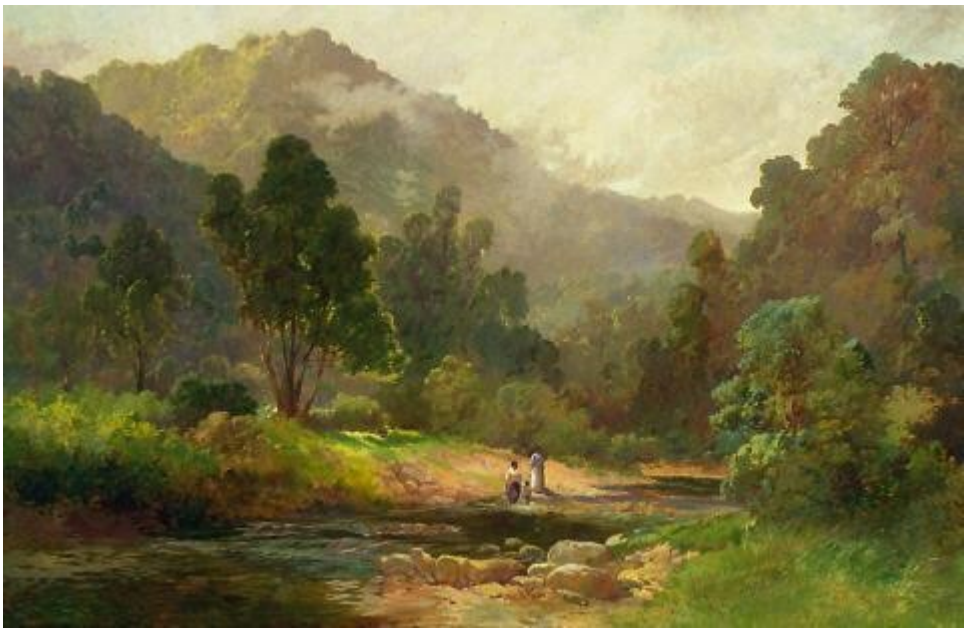
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1899/2/3

12 / 20

Morning after Rain

Frank Wright

1912 · Auckland Art Gallery Toi o Tāmaki



Frank Wright. Morning after rain. Image credit: Frank Wright; Source credit: http://www.aucklandartgallery.com/explore-art-and-ideas/artwork/262/morning-after-rain. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The light catches selected patches rather than evenly illuminating the vegetation. Wright makes the title's clearing weather visible through that unevenness. Path and stream provide routes through the scene, with small figures locating an inhabited opening. The landscape's activity lies as much in changing conditions as in what its people happen to be doing.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1912/9/7

13 / 20

The Last Gleam

Frank Wright

1912 · Auckland Art Gallery Toi o Tāmaki



Frank Wright. The Last Gleam. Image credit: Frank Wright; Source credit: http://www.aucklandartgallery.com/explore-art-and-ideas/artwork/11719/the-last-gleam. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The headland still receives light after the near water and shore have entered cooler shadow. That separation gives the title a precise basis: the last brightness occupies a particular part of the view, not the whole sky. The painting makes an interval of time readable through the unequal conditions of surfaces at different distances.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: U/297

14 / 20

HMS Resolution and HMS Adventure off Cape Palliser

Matthew Thomas Clayton

1898 · Auckland Art Gallery Toi o Tāmaki



Matthew Thomas Clayton. HMS Resolution, Captain Jas Cook, and HMS Adventure, Captain Furneaux, off Cape Palliser, New Zealand, in 1773. Image credit: Matthew Thomas Clayton; Source credit: http://www.aucklandartgallery.com/explore-art-and-ideas/artwork/174/hms-resolution-captain-jas-cook-and-hms-adventure-captain-furneaux-off-cape-palliser-new-zealan. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The ships' angled masts occupy little space beneath the heavy weather. Clayton's later historical reconstruction makes the vessels vulnerable to a sea that will not become a neutral stage for exploration. The picture should not be mistaken for firsthand documentation of the voyage. Its scale and atmosphere show how the episode was subsequently imagined.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1899/3

15 / 20

Landing of Lieutenant Governor Hobson at Waitangi

Matthew Thomas Clayton

1896 · Auckland Art Gallery Toi o Tāmaki



Matthew Thomas Clayton. Landing of Lieutenant Governor Hobson at Waitangi. Image credit: Matthew Thomas Clayton; Source credit: http://www.aucklandartgallery.com/explore-art-and-ideas/artwork/1955/landing-of-lieutenant-governor-hobson-at-waitangi. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Small groups and boats gather along a shore dwarfed by the broad harbour. The spacious arrangement makes the landing appear orderly, but an orderly composition is not evidence of an uncomplicated colonial event. This later reconstruction needs to be read as a chosen representation. Ask what its distant viewpoint makes easy to see and what it leaves hard to distinguish.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1953/18

16 / 20

Queen Street, Auckland

Jacques Carabain

1889 · Auckland Art Gallery Toi o Tāmaki



Jacques Carabain. Queen Street, Auckland. Image credit: Jacques Carabain; Source credit: OAHFvUTHUA75Sg at Google Cultural Institute maximum zoom level. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Commercial façades converge towards the distance, providing a clear structure for the street's traffic. Carabain distributes pedestrians and vehicles within that architectural scale rather than letting one incident take over. The city appears through use as well as construction. The small moving figures make the height and extent of the buildings easier to judge.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1986/5

17 / 20

Auckland from the Wharf

Edward Augustus Gifford

1887 · Auckland Art Gallery Toi o Tāmaki



Edward Augustus Gifford. Auckland from the Wharf. Image credit: Edward Augustus Gifford; Source credit: http://www.aucklandartgallery.com/explore-art-and-ideas/artwork/144/auckland-from-the-wharf. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Masts and rigging stand between the viewer and the city buildings. Gifford gives the point of arrival and trade a busy foreground of its own, preventing the waterfront from becoming a clean architectural elevation. Access to the city is pictured through working vessels. The obstructions explain the place as much as the skyline does.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1889/6

18 / 20

A Settler's Kitchen, Opua Whanga

Robert Atkinson

1886 · Auckland Art Gallery Toi o Tāmaki



Robert Atkinson. A Settler's Kitchen, Opua Whanga, New Zealand 1886. Image credit: Robert Atkinson; Source credit: http://www.aucklandartgallery.com/explore-art-and-ideas/artwork/8179/a-settlers-kitchen-opua-whanga-new-zealand-1886. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

No inhabitant is needed to make the hearth a centre of activity. Kettle, utensils and rough boards locate daily tasks through objects and their arrangement. Atkinson gives the interior a specificity that a generalised account of domestic hardship would miss. Wear can indicate use without supplying an invented biography for the people who used the room.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1999/22

19 / 20

A Cavalry Battle

Salvator Rosa

1652 · Auckland Art Gallery Toi o Tāmaki



Salvator Rosa. A Cavalry Battle. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Rosa withholds a single isolated hero who could make the fighting easy to follow. Horses, weapons and bodies overlap in small actions beneath the dark sky. The difficulty of disentangling them becomes part of the subject. Architecture offers fragments of a setting rather than a secure stage from which to survey the whole encounter.

Object source · Open artwork

20 / 20

The Obsequies of an Egyptian Cat

John Reinhard Weguelin

1886 · Auckland Art Gallery Toi o Tāmaki



John Reinhard Weguelin. The Obsequies of an Egyptian Cat. Image credit: John Weguelin (1849 - 1927) – Creator (Great Britain) Details on Google Art Project; Source credit: 9AECnKpwFVU2-A at Google Cultural Institute maximum zoom level. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The ceremony is made legible through its carefully arranged vessels, offerings and animal-shaped coffin. Weguelin gives an imagined ancient ritual the detailed furnishings of a staged scene. Precision of description should not be confused with archaeological certainty. The picture reveals a nineteenth-century reconstruction of antiquity, whose convincing objects are also instruments of invention.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: MU/147

Keep the viewpoint in the question

Compare a coast partially hidden by grass with a historical scene presented from a broad distance. Neither framing is neutral. These entries follow selected holdings at Auckland Art Gallery Toi o Tāmaki; check current display information before expecting to find all the works in the galleries.

Further reading

The Practice and Science of Drawing

Harold Speed · Read free · English

Harold Speed's Practice and Science of Drawing separates questions of line, mass and rhythm. Those chapters offer a practical way to compare Angus's firm shapes with the softer landscape painting in this guide.

Museum website · Official collection guide

Sources and visitor information checked: 2026-10-12

Artline · Auckland Art Gallery Toi o Tāmaki: Masterpieces